

The Instability Itself Is the Institution: Ministerial Survival and Institutional Learning in Peru, 1821–2026

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Abstract

Why do political systems that change so much change so little in how they govern? This paper addresses that question through an original dataset of 1,062 ministerial spells covering five portfolios in Peru from 1821 to 2026. Rather than treating ministerial duration as the outcome to be explained, we treat it as a signal: an observable trace of the continuity conditions under which governing experience either accumulates into institutional knowledge or is repeatedly lost. We organize the analysis around two analytical heuristics. The first is the institutional epoch — the path-dependent period between critical junctures — which captures whether successive historical ruptures produced durable improvements in continuity conditions. The second is the protective belt — a localized architecture of external accountability relationships that, where it exists, insulates certain ministries from the political logic governing the rest of the cabinet. Kaplan–Meier survival curves, log-rank tests, and Cox proportional hazards models show that epochs explain ministerial survival far better than individual traits or portfolio membership, and that continuity conditions did not improve monotonically across two centuries. The largest shift in the data occurred between the Oligarchic State and the Power-Sharing epoch; the most recent democratic period represents a partial regression toward the founding pattern of chronic interruption. The protective belt emerges only after 1993, when external accountability structures raised the cost of Economy minister replacement beyond what domestic political pressure alone could sustain. The central theoretical finding is that chronic ministerial instability in Peru is not evidence of absent institutions but of a durable informal one: the escape valve through which political pressure is absorbed without producing structural change. The instability itself is the institution.

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“Se vogliamo che tutto rimanga
com’è, bisogna che tutto cambi.”

Il Gattopardo

Giuseppe Tomasi di Lampedusa,
1958

Introduction

Governing is hard. Education, health, public safety, and economic development are not technical problems with known solutions, but complex social challenges that demand sustained institutional effort. Good policy takes time to design, time to implement, and even longer to produce visible social outcomes. Good practices diffuse gradually. Organizations accumulate knowledge slowly. Institutional learning emerges only when that accumulated knowledge is preserved, transmitted, and refined across successive administrations. Citizens experience meaningful change only after years of coherent action in the same direction. In the long run, successful governance depends less on isolated political decisions than on the organizational conditions that allow knowledge to persist beyond individual officeholders.

After more than two hundred years of republican life, the Peruvian political class has repeatedly changed governments, cabinets, constitutions, and political coalitions. Yet the underlying pattern remains remarkably stable. Each new administration appoints a cabinet whose members understand, implicitly or explicitly, the terms of their engagement: they are expected to manage complexity on behalf of the president, but they may also be sacrificed whenever political pressure demands a visible response. Their departure rarely resolves the conflict that triggered it. The resignation of a premier or any other minister may relieve immediate pressure, but it seldom addresses the underlying causes of crisis. Cabinet reshuffles therefore signal political responsiveness without necessarily producing institutional correction.

This persistence should not be mistaken for an absence of adaptation. Political actors continuously learn how to navigate constitutional ambiguities, manage public blame, and deploy ministerial replacement as a mechanism for absorbing political pressure. If the political class has accumulated any expertise, it has largely been in reproducing established responses to crisis rather than transforming the institutional conditions that generate those crises. Governments change. Ministers change. Yet the repertoire through which instability is managed remains remarkably stable. This cycle has characterized much of Peru’s republican history.

Political scientists often describe this type of persistence through the concept of path dependence, whereby accumulated institutional choices progressively constrain subsequent alternatives. Yet paths do break. Roman Krznaric (2024) argues that transformative institutional change requires what he calls a *disruption nexus*: a major crisis, social movements capable of amplifying that crisis, and a compelling institu-

tional idea ready to occupy the political space created by disruption. France's Fifth Republic illustrates this dynamic. The Algerian War provided the crisis, Gaullism supplied the political movement, and constitutional redesign centered on a strong executive offered the institutional solution. The resulting transformation was not the product of a single event but the culmination of decades of unresolved executive instability. More importantly, it fundamentally altered the conditions under which political continuity was produced. The legacy of the Fifth Republic was therefore not merely institutional reform, but a durable change in the patterns of executive stability that had characterized French politics for more than a century.

Prior to the Fifth Republic, France exhibited levels of executive instability comparable to those observed throughout much of Peru's republican history. Figure 1 illustrates this similarity. Peru reached twenty-three premier appointments during the 1890s, while France reached twenty during the 1930s. After 1958, however, the trajectories diverged sharply. French premier appointments declined to a stable range of three to six per decade and have remained there ever since, whereas Peru has gradually returned to levels characteristic of the nineteenth century. Peru has experienced no shortage of potential disruption nexuses—or, as they will later be conceptualized in this paper, critical junctures: independence without effective state-building, the War of the Pacific, hyperinflation, political violence, the collapse of the Fujimori regime, and the prolonged constitutional crisis beginning in 2016. Each represented a historical moment in which alternative institutional trajectories became plausible.

The central question, however, is not whether institutional change occurred. Peru's republican history is full of constitutional reforms, regime transitions, and political ruptures. The more fundamental question is whether these transformations altered the organizational conditions under which knowledge could be preserved, accumulated, and transmitted over time. From this perspective, a critical juncture matters not simply because it generates new institutional arrangements, but because it may establish a durable political framework capable of reshaping the conditions under which organizations accumulate knowledge and governments learn. France appears to have experienced such a transformation after 1958. Peru's trajectory raises the possibility that institutional innovation and organizational learning do not necessarily coincide.

This paper approaches that question through ministerial continuity. Ministerial duration is not interpreted as evidence of organizational learning itself. Rather, it constitutes observable evidence about the organizational conditions under which knowledge may accumulate. Organizations do not preserve knowledge because particular individuals remain indefinitely in office. Instead, sustained continuity creates opportunities for organizational routines, institutional memory, policy procedures, and accumulated expertise to be retained and transmitted despite inevitable personnel turnover. Ministerial continuity therefore represents a necessary—although not sufficient—condition for organizational knowledge accumulation.

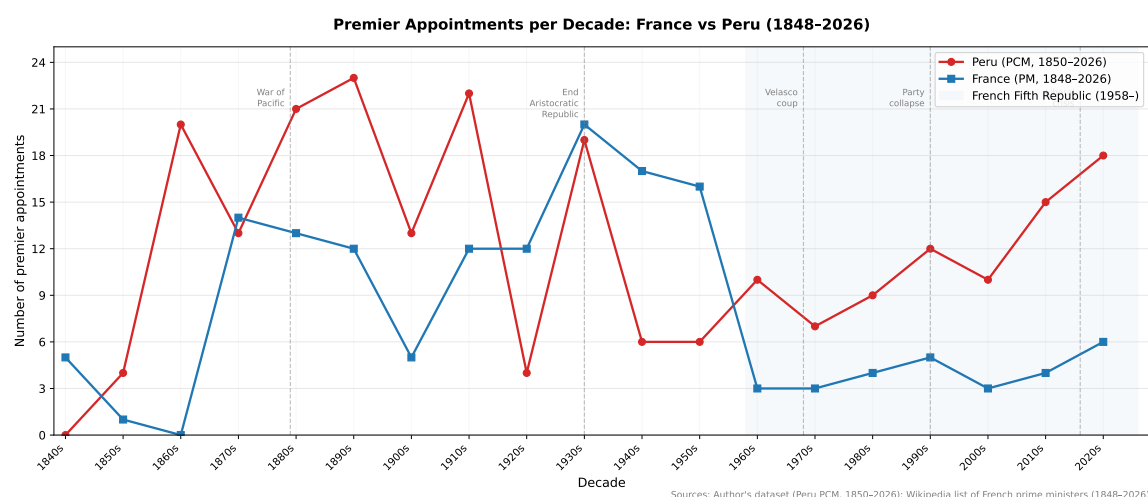


Figure 1

Premier Appointments per Decade: France vs. Peru, 1848–2026.

Sources: Author's dataset (based on Gálvez Montero and García Vega (2016a, 2016b)); Wikipedia list of French prime ministers (1848–2026).

Political science has traditionally examined these issues through separate research traditions. Ministerial duration has been analyzed using survival and event-history methods, whereas long-term institutional development has largely been studied through the comparative-historical literature on path dependence and critical junctures. This paper connects these traditions by reconceptualizing ministerial continuity as an observable indicator of the organizational conditions required for knowledge accumulation and institutional learning.

The empirical strategy follows two complementary heuristics derived from the theoretical framework developed below. The first examines variation in ministerial continuity across historically distinct political frameworks in order to evaluate how opportunities for organizational knowledge accumulation changed over time. The second compares continuity across ministerial portfolios operating within the same political framework, recognizing that some organizations may become partially insulated from the broader political dynamics affecting the cabinet as a whole. Together, these perspectives distinguish historical variation from organizational variation in the conditions under which organizational knowledge may accumulate.

The question guiding this study is straightforward: *Have Peru's successive political frameworks generated different opportunities for the accumulation of organizational knowledge?*

This question cannot be answered directly because organizational knowledge is not directly observable in historical records. Instead, the analysis evaluates the necessary organizational condition under which knowledge may accumulate: continuity. If organizational continuity constitutes a prerequisite for knowledge accumulation, then

systematic differences in ministerial continuity should reveal systematic differences in the opportunities available for organizations to preserve, accumulate, and transmit knowledge over time.

The theoretical framework translates this general question into three empirical questions. *First*, what continuity conditions characterized Peru’s successive political frameworks? *Second*, did those continuity conditions differ systematically across political frameworks? *Third*, within the same political framework, did some ministerial portfolios systematically exhibit greater continuity than others?

To answer these questions, we construct an original dataset of individual ministerial spells covering the period from 1821 to 2026. The analysis focuses on five portfolios that capture distinct organizational functions within the executive branch. The Presidency of the Council of Ministers (PCM) represents the political center responsible for coordinating cabinet action and maintaining executive cohesion. The Ministry of Economy and Finance (MEF) represents the technocratic center responsible for fiscal and macroeconomic policy. The Ministries of Interior, Health, and Education represent policy sectors confronting some of Peru’s most persistent governance challenges according to official yearly surveys (INEI, 2024). Ministerial spells are subsequently organized into historically distinct political frameworks derived from Peru’s critical junctures (Lopez Jimenez et al., 2025). Combining descriptive analyses with survival models, the study evaluates how organizational continuity varied across political frameworks and ministerial portfolios, thereby providing empirical evidence about the organizational conditions under which knowledge accumulation becomes possible.

1 Literature Review

The political science literature on ministerial survival has converged around two broad families of explanations. The first explains variation in ministerial tenure through characteristics of ministers themselves. The second emphasizes the political and institutional environments within which ministers operate. Table 1 summarizes the principal covariates identified across the core studies.

1.1 Trait-Based Explanations of Ministerial Survival

Trait-based approaches explain ministerial survival through characteristics of the officeholder. Across different institutional settings, scholars have shown that ministers’ professional backgrounds, political careers, partisan affiliations, and personal resources influence their probability of remaining in office. Early studies emphasized broad distinctions between managerial and parliamentary profiles, as well as the effects of career trajectories and prior political experience (Blondel, 1988). Subsequent work expanded the range of relevant characteristics to include age, education, gender, portfolio rank, and seniority within government (Dewan & Dowding, 2005; Fischer et al., 2012).

Table 1*Trait-based and Context-based Predictors of Ministerial Survival*

Author(s)	Trait-based	Context-based
Blondel (1988)	Career duration; parliamentary vs. managerial profile	Party system norms; head-of-government style; country context
Huber & Martínez-Gallardo (2008)	Ideological distance from government center; PM party membership; portfolio importance	Coalition type; minority government; electoral volatility; party fractionalization
Dewan & Dowding (2005)	Resignation issue salience; ministerial seniority	PM support level; media attention; single-party vs. coalition system
Fischer et al. (2012)	Age; education; gender; portfolio rank	PM popularity; regime type; frequency of resignation calls
Camerlo & Pérez-Liñán (2015)	Portfolio type; technocrat/partisan/outsider profile; first cabinet appointment	Protests; scandals; electoral calendar; term limits; reelection rules
Camerlo & Castaldo (2024)	Partisan rank within party hierarchy (leader, high-rank, low-rank, newcomer, shadow, defector)	Party government model applicability; regime type; party institutionalization level
Feliú Ribeiro & López Burian (2023)	Technical expertise; presidential group membership; prior electoral experience (<i>risk factor</i>)	Economic growth; GDP per capita; legislative powers; regime type; portfolio area
Mejía et al. (2021)	Education; gender; regional origin; prior elected office	Coalition type; legislative majority; party-system change
Alexiadou & Gunaydin (2019)	Technocratic profile; non-partisan status; reform commitment	Economic crisis severity; electoral system type; party control of portfolio
Baturo & Elkind (2014)	Personal traits as time-invariant officeholder effects (education, prior career)	Regime institutionalization; personalization vs. office-based authority
Jara Iñiguez & Cedeño Alcívar (2019)	Managerial performance lifecycle (inverted-U over tenure)	Presidential appointment and dismissal capacity; political trust as selection criterion

More recent research has refined these categories by focusing on the organizational and political resources that ministers bring to office. Feliú Ribeiro and López Burian show that technical expertise and membership in presidential networks increase ministerial survival, while prior electoral experience may paradoxically operate as a risk factor (Feliú Ribeiro & López Burian, 2023). Across four Latin American countries between 1945 and 2020, career politicians proved more vulnerable to dismissal than technocrats. The finding suggests that ministerial value cannot be reduced to political experience alone; survival depends on the type of resources political leaders seek to preserve.

The literature has also moved beyond simple dichotomies between partisan and non-partisan ministers. Camerlo and Castaldo argue that partisan affiliation conceals substantial variation in the strength of a minister's relationship with the party organization. Their framework distinguishes among leaders, high-ranks, low-ranks, newcomers, shadows, and defectors according to levels of engagement, consolidation, and hierarchical position within the party (Camerlo & Castaldo, 2024). Applied to the Argentine cabinet under Alberto Fernández, this approach reveals that apparently strong partisan cabinets may actually consist of ministers with limited organizational leverage over their parties (Camerlo et al., 2024). Ministers sharing the same partisan label therefore possess very different capacities to withstand political pressure.

Taken together, these studies demonstrate that ministerial duration is shaped

by who ministers are. Technical expertise, organizational embeddedness, political experience, and personal resources all influence survival prospects. Yet the effects of these traits depend fundamentally on the environments in which ministers operate. The same characteristic may be rewarded in one institutional setting and penalized in another. This observation leads naturally to the second major family of explanations.

1.2 Context-Based Explanations of Ministerial Survival

Context-based approaches explain ministerial survival through characteristics of the political environment rather than characteristics of individual ministers. Ministers survive or fail because of the institutional and political constraints surrounding them.

The comparative literature consistently identifies coalition dynamics as a central determinant of ministerial duration. Coalition type, minority government status, electoral volatility, and party-system fragmentation all shape the likelihood of ministerial replacement independently of individual characteristics (Huber & Martínez-Gallardo, 2008). Similarly, political crises, scandals, protests, electoral calendars, and term limits alter the incentives presidents face when deciding whether to retain or dismiss ministers (Alexiadou & Gunaydin, 2019; Camerlo & Pérez-Liñán, 2015). Even macroeconomic performance influences survival probabilities by modifying the broader political environment within which governments operate (Feliú Ribeiro & López Burian, 2023).

The case literature illustrates these mechanisms particularly clearly. For Colombia, Mejía Guinand et al. find that although individual characteristics matter, the institutional configuration of the political system ultimately determines the range within which those characteristics can operate (Mejía et al., 2021). Constitutional reforms, changes in party-system structure, and coalition arrangements alter the political logic governing ministerial careers. Similar conclusions emerge from Chile, where Avendaño and Dávila show that ministerial turnover during the Concertación governments was driven primarily by coalition management rather than by individual performance. Finance ministers consistently exhibited the longest tenures regardless of their personal characteristics (Avendaño & Dávila, 2012).

Recent work has also refined the contextual analysis of ministerial portfolios. Portfolio importance has traditionally been measured through expert rankings that assign ministries a single level of salience. Camerlo and Martínez-Gallardo argue that such measures obscure important differences among ministries, particularly in contexts characterized by weak party institutionalization (Camerlo & Gallardo, 2022). Their framework decomposes ministerial value into policy-management capacity, discretionary resource allocation, political agenda influence, and inter-portfolio coordination authority. Different political environments activate different dimensions of portfolio value, producing distinct survival incentives for presidents and ministers alike.

Taken together, these studies demonstrate that ministerial survival depends

not only on who ministers are but also on where they operate. Institutional structures, coalition arrangements, political crises, economic conditions, and portfolio characteristics jointly define the opportunities and constraints governing ministerial careers.

1.3 Reinterpreting Ministerial Continuity

The two families of explanations are not competing research programs. Virtually every empirical study combines individual and contextual covariates, with political environments conditioning the effects of ministerial characteristics. Together, these studies provide a rich understanding of why some ministers survive longer than others.

Despite their differences, however, they share an implicit assumption: ministerial duration is itself the phenomenon to be explained. Consequently, continuity is interpreted primarily as the outcome of cabinet management, coalition bargaining, institutional constraints, or individual characteristics. This common orientation leaves unexplored a different analytical possibility. Rather than asking why ministers remain in office, ministerial continuity may be interpreted as observable evidence about the organizational conditions under which governments preserve accumulated knowledge and develop institutional learning.

This paper adopts that alternative perspective. Ministerial continuity is not treated as evidence of organizational learning itself, nor does it imply that knowledge resides in individual ministers. Rather, continuity provides the organizational condition under which knowledge embedded in routines, procedures, institutional memory, and accumulated administrative experience can be preserved, transmitted, and refined over time despite inevitable personnel turnover. Organizations, not individuals, are therefore the principal unit through which knowledge accumulates.

This reinterpretation shifts the analytical focus from explaining individual ministerial survival to understanding the organizational conditions that make institutional learning possible. Instead of treating ministerial duration as a dependent variable, the paper treats patterns of continuity as empirical evidence about the capacity of political organizations to preserve and accumulate knowledge across successive governments.

The next section develops a deductive theoretical framework organized around two axioms and three propositions. The first axiom establishes organizational continuity as the necessary condition for organizational knowledge accumulation. The second identifies organizational knowledge accumulation as the necessary condition for institutional learning. Building upon these foundations, the propositions explain why continuity varies across political frameworks, how political frameworks generate different configurations of organizational protection, and why those protective arrangements produce differentiated continuity across ministerial portfolios. Together, these axioms and propositions provide the conceptual foundation for interpreting ministerial continuity as observable evidence about the organizational conditions under which knowledge accumulation and institutional learning become possible.

2 Theoretical Framework

The theoretical framework developed in this paper follows an axiomatic–deductive strategy. Rather than beginning with hypotheses to be statistically tested, it begins by specifying a set of latent organizational constructs together with the fundamental relationships that connect them. These relationships are expressed as axioms. They are not empirical hypotheses and therefore are not themselves subjected to statistical testing. Instead, they establish the theoretical ontology from which observable implications are deductively derived.

The observable implications of the theory are formulated as propositions. Unlike the axioms, the propositions are expressed exclusively in terms of observable historical quantities. Their role is to translate the latent theoretical relationships into empirical expectations that may be examined using historical evidence. Consequently, the empirical analyses developed later do not test the axioms directly. Rather, they evaluate whether the observable implications implied by the propositions are approximated by Peru’s historical trajectory.

This distinction is fundamental for the methodological strategy adopted throughout the paper. Definitions establish the meaning of the theoretical constructs. Axioms specify the fundamental relationships among those latent constructs. Propositions translate those relationships into observable historical implications. Statistical analyses therefore evaluate observable duration patterns, while the axioms provide the theoretical interpretation of those patterns. In this sense, the statistical analyses neither verify nor falsify the axioms themselves; instead, they assess the extent to which the empirical record is consistent with the observable implications derived from the deductive framework.

Throughout the discussion, arrows ($\rightarrow$) denote deductive theoretical relationships rather than estimated causal effects. Unless explicitly stated otherwise, they should be interpreted as expressing enabling or necessary relationships among the constructs composing the theoretical framework.

2.1 Definitions

Organizational continuity (C) refers to the persistence of organizational processes through time despite the inevitable turnover of individual officeholders. Continuity concerns the preservation of organizational routines, procedures, institutional memory, and administrative practices rather than the permanence of particular individuals in office.

Organizational knowledge accumulation (K) refers to the process through which experience becomes progressively embedded in organizational routines, procedures, and institutional memory. Organizational knowledge is therefore understood as an organizational property rather than as an attribute of individual officeholders.

Institutional learning (IL) refers to the capacity of political institutions to improve governing practices by incorporating accumulated organizational knowledge into future institutional arrangements. Institutional learning is therefore conceived as an institutional property emerging from organizational processes rather than from the experiences of individual political actors.

Protective belts (PB) refer to latent organizational arrangements that preserve organizational continuity by increasing the political or administrative costs associated with disrupting organizational routines. Protective belts protect organizational continuity rather than individual officeholders.

Political Frameworks (PF) refer to historically bounded institutional environments produced by completed Critical Junctures. Political Frameworks constitute the observable historical contexts within which governmental organizations operate.

2.2 Axiom A1: Organizational Continuity Enables Organizational Knowledge Accumulation

The first axiom establishes the organizational foundation of the theoretical framework. Organizations are temporal entities. Unlike isolated political decisions, organizational processes unfold through repeated interaction, the preservation of routines, and the retention of institutional memory. Consequently, organizational knowledge cannot accumulate independently of some degree of organizational continuity.

The first axiom is stated as

$$C \rightarrow K \tag{A1}$$

where C denotes organizational continuity and K denotes organizational knowledge accumulation.

Axiom A1 should be interpreted as expressing an enabling organizational relationship rather than a deterministic causal claim. Organizational continuity makes knowledge accumulation possible by allowing experience to be retained, articulated, transmitted, and progressively incorporated into organizational routines. It does not imply that organizations necessarily learn, innovate, or improve. The axiom identifies continuity as a necessary organizational condition for knowledge accumulation, not as a sufficient condition for organizational success.

Although introduced here as a foundational premise, Axiom A1 is broadly compatible with several established research traditions. Organizational learning theory emphasizes that knowledge emerges cumulatively through repeated interaction, articulation, retention, and routinization (Levitt & March, 1988; Nonaka, 1998). Conversely, the notion of *organized anarchy* highlights how fluid participation disrupts the organizational continuity required for shared learning and stable organizational memory (Cohen et al., 1972). Public policy theory reinforces the same principle by

emphasizing that complex decision-making depends upon sequential problem structuring, incremental refinement, routines, and standard operating procedures (Allison, 1969; Foss & Foss, 2005; Lindblom, 1959).

Taken together, these literatures converge on a common organizational premise: organizations preserve knowledge through continuity. Axiom A1 adopts this premise as the first deductive foundation of the framework.

2.3 Axiom A2: Organizational Knowledge Accumulation Enables Institutional Learning

Axiom A1 established the organizational condition under which knowledge may accumulate. A second and conceptually distinct question concerns the institutional consequences of accumulated organizational knowledge. Under what conditions can political institutions themselves be said to learn?

The second axiom is stated as

$$K \rightarrow IL \quad (A2)$$

where K denotes organizational knowledge accumulation and IL denotes institutional learning.

Axiom A2 should be interpreted as expressing an enabling institutional relationship rather than a deterministic causal claim. Accumulated organizational knowledge provides the experiential foundation upon which institutional learning may occur, but it does not guarantee that political institutions will adapt successfully or improve their governing capacity. Political institutions may preserve substantial organizational knowledge while continuing to reproduce ineffective routines, maladaptive organizational arrangements, or unsuccessful policy choices. The axiom therefore identifies organizational knowledge accumulation as a necessary precondition for institutional learning, not as a sufficient condition for institutional improvement.

This premise is broadly compatible with organizational and policy learning literatures. Fiol and Lyles distinguish between accumulated experience and learning, emphasizing that learning requires shared understandings capable of influencing future organizational action (Fiol & Lyles, 1985). Olsen extends this logic to political institutions by treating constitutions, administrative routines, laws, and organizational practices as repositories of accumulated knowledge through which institutions interpret experience and adapt over time (Olsen, 2010). Similarly, Hall's account of policy learning emphasizes that governments revise policy goals, instruments, and governing practices on the basis of accumulated experience rather than isolated political responses (Hall, 1993).

Axiom A2 therefore locates institutional learning at a higher analytical level than organizational knowledge accumulation. Knowledge remains an organizational property; institutional learning is an institutional property that may emerge when

accumulated organizational knowledge is preserved, interpreted, and incorporated into future governing practices.

2.4 Axiom A3: Protective Belts Preserve Organizational Continuity

Axioms A1 and A2 established that organizational continuity enables organizational knowledge accumulation and that accumulated organizational knowledge enables institutional learning. A third question naturally follows. If organizational continuity is repeatedly exposed to political turnover, under what conditions can it be preserved?

The third axiom is stated as

$$PB \rightarrow C \tag{A3}$$

where PB denotes the strength of a Protective Belt and C denotes organizational continuity.

Axiom A3 expresses an enabling organizational relationship rather than a deterministic causal claim. Protective Belts increase the likelihood that organizational continuity will be preserved by raising the political, institutional, administrative, or societal costs associated with organizational disruption. They do not guarantee continuity, nor do they protect individual officeholders. Political leaders remain free to appoint and dismiss ministers whenever political circumstances require. Rather, the axiom states that organizations surrounded by stronger Protective Belts are more likely to preserve the organizational conditions under which routines, institutional memory, procedures, and accumulated knowledge can persist despite recurrent political turnover.

Although introduced here as an axiomatic premise, the organizational logic underlying Protective Belts draws upon several complementary theoretical traditions. Organizational sociology emphasizes that complex organizations develop stable systems of regulation, interdependence, and collective action that reduce arbitrary organizational disruption (Crozier & Thoenig, 1976). Historical institutionalism explains how institutional arrangements generate increasing costs of reversal as organizational capabilities, coordination, learning, and stakeholder expectations accumulate over time (Pierson, 2000). Bureaucratic politics further shows that governmental organizations may acquire reputational capital and broad external support that make political intervention increasingly costly, thereby generating forms of bureaucratic autonomy extending beyond formal legal protections (Carpenter, 2020). Finally, institutional theories of political decision-making demonstrate that political actors rarely exercise unconstrained discretion. Instead, institutional configurations impose differential political costs on organizational and policy change, making some forms of intervention substantially more difficult than others (Tsebelis, 1995).

Importantly, none of these traditions independently explains the emergence of Protective Belts. Rather, each identifies a distinct mechanism through which organi-

zational disruption becomes increasingly costly. Organizational regulation generates internal stability; increasing returns make accumulated organizational capabilities progressively more valuable; bureaucratic reputation creates external political support; and institutional constraints limit discretionary political intervention. The concept of the Protective Belt synthesizes these complementary mechanisms into a single latent construct representing the aggregate protection surrounding a governmental organization. Consequently, Protective Belts are not directly observed but inferred from systematic differences in organizational continuity across otherwise comparable governmental organizations.

Evidence consistent with this organizational logic appears in comparative studies of ministerial survival. Feliú Ribeiro and López Burian show that foreign affairs portfolios exhibit substantially longer ministerial survival than most domestic portfolios across Latin America. They argue that foreign ministers become accountable not only to domestic political actors but also to international audiences, thereby increasing the political costs associated with ministerial replacement (Feliú Ribeiro & López Burian, 2023). Their findings illustrate how broader political constraints may be translated into differentiated organizational protection.

Together, Axioms A1–A3 define the latent organizational structure of the theoretical framework,

$$PB \rightarrow C \rightarrow K \rightarrow IL.$$

The three axioms are not intended to explain historical variation. Rather, they specify the organizational conditions under which institutional learning becomes possible. The propositions that follow translate this latent organizational structure into observable implications expressed exclusively in terms of Political Frameworks, governmental organizations, and ministerial duration.

2.5 From Latent Theory to Observable Propositions

The three axioms establish relationships among latent organizational constructs and are therefore not directly testable. Empirical evaluation requires translating those latent relationships into observable implications. Throughout this paper, Political Frameworks and governmental organizations constitute observable historical entities, while ministerial duration serves as an observable indicator of organizational continuity. Consequently, the propositions that follow are expressed exclusively in terms of observable quantities. Their theoretical interpretation is subsequently derived from Axioms A1–A3.

2.5.1 *Proposition 1: Ministerial Duration across Political Frameworks*

The first proposition concerns historical variation in ministerial duration across successive Political Frameworks. Within the comparative-historical tradition, Critical Junctures are understood as relatively brief episodes of institutional transformation

that generate durable political legacies and define subsequent periods of political development (Capoccia & Kelemen, 2007). Rather than examining the Critical Junc-tures themselves, this study analyzes the Political Frameworks that emerge from them. Following established principles of concept formation and operationalization in comparative-historical research (Collier & Munck, 2022), Political Frameworks constitute the observable historical environments within which governmental organi-zations operate. Consequently, the empirical analysis does not search inductively for historical breakpoints. Instead, it evaluates whether observed patterns of ministerial duration are consistent with a theoretically motivated historical periodization.

The first proposition is therefore stated as

$$D_{f+1} > D_f, \quad f = 1, \dots, F - 1, \quad (\text{P1})$$

where D_f denotes the observed ministerial duration under Political Framework f , and F denotes the total number of Political Frameworks.

Observable implication. Successive Political Frameworks are expected to exhibit progressively longer patterns of ministerial duration.

Theoretical implication. According to Axioms A1 and A2, progressively longer patterns of ministerial duration imply increasingly favorable organizational conditions for organizational knowledge accumulation and, consequently, institutional learning. Conversely, the absence of progressively longer duration patterns would indicate that the historical record provides no evidence that successive Political Frame-works generated increasingly favorable conditions for institutional learning.

2.5.2 *Proposition 2: Ministerial Duration across Portfolios within Po-litical Frameworks*

Whereas Proposition P1 examines historical variation across Political Frame-works, the second proposition concerns organizational variation within Political Frameworks. If a Political Framework constitutes the common historical environ-ment under which governmental organizations operate, then differences in ministerial duration observed within the same Political Framework cannot be attributed to the historical framework alone. Instead, they indicate systematic variation associated with ministerial portfolios.

The principal comparison concerns the Ministry of Economy and Finance (MEF) and the Presidency of the Council of Ministers (PCM). As argued in the pre-vious section, the selective reconstruction of the Peruvian state following the reforms of the 1990s provides strong theoretical reasons to expect that macroeconomic gover-nance became surrounded by stronger organizational protection than governmental organizations primarily responsible for political coordination. Additional ministerial portfolios are incorporated as organizational benchmarks and robustness checks.

The second proposition is therefore stated as

$$D_{pf} \neq D_{p'f}, \quad p \neq p', \quad (\text{P2})$$

where D_{pf} denotes the observed ministerial duration of portfolio p operating under Political Framework f , and p and p' denote distinct ministerial portfolios.

Observable implication. Within the same Political Framework, ministerial duration is expected to vary systematically across ministerial portfolios.

Theoretical implication. According to Axiom A3, systematic differences in ministerial duration across portfolios operating under the same Political Framework are interpreted as evidence consistent with differential Protective Belts. Portfolios exhibiting greater ministerial continuity are inferred to possess stronger Protective Belts because the political, institutional, administrative, and societal costs associated with organizational disruption are comparatively higher.

3 Peru as an Empirical Application

The theoretical framework developed in the previous section proposes a general explanation linking Political Frameworks, organizational continuity, organizational knowledge accumulation, institutional learning, and Protective Belts. These concepts are not specific to Peru. Rather, they describe historical and organizational processes that could, in principle, operate in any political system. Peru is therefore introduced not because the theory was derived from the Peruvian experience, but because its republican history provides an unusually informative empirical application through which the observable implications of the framework can be evaluated.

The empirical value of Peru lies in the coexistence of two characteristics that rarely appear simultaneously. First, nearly two centuries of republican continuity encompass multiple episodes of profound institutional transformation, allowing the identification of successive Political Frameworks generated by completed Critical Junctures. Second, despite these repeated historical reconfigurations, the Peruvian executive has maintained a broadly comparable ministerial organization, permitting the study of ministerial continuity under different historical environments while holding the basic organizational architecture of government relatively constant.

From the perspective adopted here, Peru therefore constitutes a natural historical laboratory. Rather than assuming that institutional reforms necessarily improve governance or generate cumulative political progress, the theoretical framework proposes that successive Political Frameworks create different organizational conditions under which governmental knowledge may accumulate. Whether these conditions became progressively more favorable over time remains an empirical question rather than a theoretical assumption. The Peruvian experience is particularly well suited to examining this question because its historical trajectory includes multiple completed Political Frameworks within which organizational continuity can be compared both across historical periods and across governmental organizations.

This section operationalizes the principal historical and organizational concepts introduced in the theoretical framework. It first reconstructs the Political Frameworks derived from Peru's completed Critical Junctures, thereby defining the

historical environments within which ministerial duration is evaluated. It then examines the selective organizational reconstruction associated with the post-1990 political settlement and explains why the selected ministerial portfolios provide theoretically informative organizational comparisons. Together, these historical and organizational operationalizations establish the empirical setting through which the observable implications of Propositions P1 and P2 are subsequently evaluated.

3.1 Political Frameworks and Critical Junctures

Political Frameworks constitute the historical environments within which ministerial duration is evaluated. Because they are analytical historical constructs, they require explicit empirical operationalization before their observable implications can be examined.

This study operationalizes Political Frameworks using the comparative-historical tradition of Critical Junctures, which conceives political development as a succession of relatively stable institutional environments separated by comparatively brief episodes of profound institutional transformation. Critical Junctures reorganize political authority, redefine governing coalitions, and establish durable institutional legacies that subsequently structure political life over extended periods of time (Capoccia & Kelemen, 2007; Collier & Munck, 2022). Consistent with the theoretical framework developed in the previous section, the Critical Junctures themselves are not the object of analysis. Rather, they constitute the historical processes through which new Political Frameworks emerge. The empirical analyses therefore focus on the relatively stable historical environments generated by completed Critical Junctures.

Following the historical reconstruction developed by Lopez Jimenez et al. (2025), Peru's republican history is organized into six successive Political Frameworks bounded by five completed Critical Junctures and a sixth Political Framework associated with an ongoing Critical Juncture. Because the current political realignment remains unresolved, the institutional legacy of the most recent framework should be regarded as provisional.

Table 2 presents the Political Frameworks employed throughout the empirical analyses. These frameworks define the successive historical environments within which ministerial duration is compared to evaluate Proposition P1.

Although each Critical Juncture emerged from distinct historical circumstances, they share an important organizational characteristic. Rather than merely replacing governments or constitutions, each fundamentally reconfigured the organizational architecture of the Peruvian state by altering governing priorities, administrative capacities, and the distribution of political authority.

The War of the Pacific exposed the absence of a coherent national state capable of coordinating military, fiscal, and administrative resources, initiating a prolonged period of state reconstruction under oligarchic leadership. The collapse of the Aristocratic Republic transformed an exclusionary political order into one increasingly

Table 2*Operationalization of Political Frameworks*

Political Framework	Period	Originating Critical Juncture	Dominant Political Legacy
PF1 – State Formation	1824–1883	Independence (1810–1824)	Failed national state-building; persistent caudillo politics; colonial institutional continuities.
PF2 – Oligarchic State	1883–1933	War of the Pacific (1879–1883)	Elite reconstruction under oligarchic rule; patrimonial state consolidation and restricted political incorporation.
PF3 – Power-Sharing State	1933–1975	Crisis of the Aristocratic Republic (1920–1933)	Tripartite political order involving oligarchy, APRA, and the armed forces; gradual incorporation of organized social actors.
PF4 – Democratic Transition and Crisis	1975–1993	Military Revolution (1968–1975)	Democratization following military rule under conditions of economic collapse, political violence, and institutional crisis.
PF5 – Democracy without Parties	1993–2022	Fujimori Settlement (1982–1992)	Neoliberal political order characterized by weak parties, electoral volatility, and sustained executive predominance.
PF6 – Current Critical Juncture	2022–Present	Collapse of the Fujimori Settlement (2021–2022)	Fragmentation of the neoliberal political order; collapse of executive-legislative equilibrium; intensified social polarization; uncertain institutional realignment still in progress.

Note: The Political Frameworks presented here constitute the historical operationalization employed throughout the empirical analyses. They represent enduring political legacies inferred from completed Critical Junctures rather than observed historical categories. Alternative operationalizations are possible under different comparative-historical interpretations. Adapted from Lopez Jimenez et al. (2025).

confronted by mass political mobilization and organized social actors. The Military Revolution radically expanded state organizational capacity through agrarian reform, nationalization, and the creation of new public institutions while simultaneously restricting democratic competition. The combined crises of terrorism, hyperinflation, and institutional collapse during the 1980s culminated in the constitutional settlement of the 1990s, which selectively reorganized the Peruvian state around macroeconomic stabilization and market governance. Finally, the contemporary political crisis initiated after the removal of President Pedro Castillo suggests that the post-1993 settlement may itself be entering a new period of institutional reconfiguration whose long-term legacy remains uncertain.

From the perspective of the present framework, the substantive importance of these transformations lies not primarily in constitutional or electoral change, but in their consequences for the organizational environments within which governmental organizations operate. Each Political Framework established a distinct configuration of governing priorities, institutional capacities, and political incentives, thereby cre-

ating different historical environments within which patterns of ministerial duration may vary.

Accordingly, the Political Frameworks summarized in Table 2 define the successive historical environments within which ministerial duration is subsequently evaluated. They provide the historical dimension required to examine whether ministerial duration exhibits the progressive patterns predicted by Proposition P1. Under Axioms A1 and A2, progressively longer patterns of ministerial duration are interpreted as evidence of increasingly favorable organizational conditions for organizational knowledge accumulation and, consequently, institutional learning.

3.2 Globalization and the Selective Reconstruction of the State

The Political Frameworks introduced in the previous subsection constitute the principal historical partition employed throughout the empirical analyses. One qualification, however, deserves attention. Although the fifth Political Framework begins with the constitutional settlement of 1993, the organizational reforms associated with Peru's reintegration into the global economy unfolded progressively throughout the following decade. Understanding this process is important not because it alters the Political Framework itself, but because it motivates additional analyses examining whether the principal findings remain robust before and after the consolidation of the post-1990 organizational settlement.

Peru's renewed integration into the global economy following the crises of the 1980s did not constitute the country's first experience with outward-oriented development. Throughout both the colonial and republican periods, successive governments repeatedly adopted development strategies centered on primary exports, liberal economic policies, and close integration with the dominant international economy of their time. What distinguished the post-1990 reforms was therefore not the adoption of market-oriented policies themselves, but the organizational response through which those policies were implemented.

The combined crises of terrorism, hyperinflation, fiscal collapse, external indebtedness, and the breakdown of the traditional party system created an exceptional opportunity for institutional redesign. Rather than simply reducing the role of the state through privatization and deregulation, successive governments gradually constructed a coherent set of fiscal, monetary, financial, and regulatory institutions capable of supporting macroeconomic stability and international economic integration (Santos et al., 2015). This process included sustained fiscal consolidation (Santos et al., 2015, Ch.5), the introduction and subsequent refinement of fiscal rules (Santos et al., 2015, Ch.6), modernization of tax administration (Santos et al., 2015, Ch.8), reforms in public financial management (Santos et al., 2015, Ch.9), the development of new frameworks for public investment and public-private partnerships (Santos et al., 2015, Ch.10–11), consolidation of an independent inflation-targeting central bank (Santos et al., 2015, Ch.12), modernization of financial supervision and macroprudential regulation (Santos et al., 2015, Ch.15–18), and the progressive expansion of trade

and foreign investment institutions (Santos et al., 2015, Ch.19). Collectively, these reforms represented not merely a shift in economic policy but a selective reconstruction of the organizational architecture of the Peruvian state.

The commodity boom of the 2000s reinforced these organizational changes. Rising fiscal revenues, expanding exports, and sustained foreign investment increased both the resources available to the state and the credibility of the institutional framework that had emerged during the previous decade. The resulting macroeconomic stability further strengthened the strategic importance of governmental organizations responsible for fiscal policy, public finance, monetary management, financial regulation, and external economic relations, while creating incentives for successive administrations to preserve rather than replace the institutional architecture already in place (Santos et al., 2015).

These developments do not redefine the fifth Political Framework established by the preceding Critical Juncture. Instead, they identify a gradual process of organizational consolidation occurring within that historical environment. The constitutional settlement established the broad political framework; the subsequent decade progressively equipped that framework with a complementary set of organizations, administrative routines, and policy instruments capable of sustaining macroeconomic governance. Consequently, while the principal empirical analyses employ the Political Frameworks defined in the previous subsection, additional analyses later examine whether the principal findings remain robust before and after the consolidation of these organizational reforms.

Finally, the selective reconstruction of macroeconomic governance provides the substantive motivation for the organizational comparisons developed in the remainder of the paper. If some governmental organizations became progressively more central to the operation of the post-1990 political settlement than others, differences in ministerial duration should be expected to emerge within the same Political Framework. The following subsection explains why the comparison between the Ministry of Economy and Finance and the Presidency of the Council of Ministers provides the principal organizational contrast through which Proposition P2 is evaluated.

3.3 Governmental Organizations as Analytical Units

The theoretical framework developed in this paper concerns governmental organizations as the primary units through which organizational continuity, organizational knowledge accumulation, institutional learning, and Protective Belts are conceptualized. These latent organizational properties are empirically operationalized through ministerial portfolios. Ministers temporarily occupy these organizations, whereas the organizations themselves persist across successive presidential administrations and Political Frameworks. Consequently, the empirical analyses compare organizations rather than individual officeholders.

The empirical application distinguishes three analytically distinct contexts within which every ministerial spell is observed. First, each spell belongs to a govern-

mental organization, operationalized as a ministerial portfolio. This constitutes the organizational unit through which the theoretical mechanisms are examined. Second, every spell occurs under a particular presidential administration, representing the executive context responsible for ministerial appointments, cabinet formation, and ministerial replacement. Third, both governmental organizations and presidential administrations operate within a Political Framework, which provides the broader historical environment within which ministerial duration is evaluated.

These three contexts should not be interpreted as forming a simple hierarchy. Governmental organizations persist across successive presidential administrations and Political Frameworks, whereas each presidential administration simultaneously governs multiple governmental organizations. Ministerial spells therefore emerge from the intersection of historical, organizational, and executive contexts rather than from a single nested structure. Throughout the empirical analyses, Political Frameworks define historical environments, governmental organizations constitute the units through which the theoretical mechanisms operate, and presidential administrations capture executive-level heterogeneity affecting observed ministerial duration.

The principal organizational comparison concerns the Ministry of Economy and Finance (MEF) and the Presidency of the Council of Ministers (PCM). Both occupy central positions within the executive branch, yet they perform fundamentally different organizational functions. The comparison is theoretically informative because both organizations participate continuously in cabinet government while facing markedly different organizational incentives. Whereas the PCM coordinates political coalitions under conditions of continual political conflict, the MEF manages specialized governmental capabilities whose effectiveness depends heavily upon technical credibility, procedural stability, standardized administrative routines, and accumulated organizational knowledge. This combination of comparable institutional position and contrasting organizational function provides the principal organizational comparison through which Proposition P2 is evaluated.

The PCM functions as the executive's principal organization for political coordination. It articulates cabinet action, negotiates with Congress, manages inter-ministerial conflicts, and preserves the political viability of the executive. Because it operates at the intersection of governmental coordination and political conflict, it is also the organization most directly exposed to recurrent political crises. Cabinet reshuffles, legislative confrontations, presidential scandals, and episodes of social unrest frequently culminate in the replacement of the Prime Minister without fundamentally altering the broader organizational structure of government. In organizational terms, the PCM functions as the executive's principal political shock absorber, absorbing political instability through leadership turnover while preserving governmental operation.

The organizational role of the MEF is fundamentally different. Rather than coordinating political coalitions, it coordinates macroeconomic governance. As discussed in the previous subsection, the post-1990 organizational settlement progres-

sively concentrated fiscal authority, budgetary management, debt administration, macroeconomic programming, public investment, and financial coordination within the MEF. These responsibilities depend upon specialized technical expertise, institutional memory, standardized administrative procedures, and accumulated organizational routines developed over time. Unlike political coordination, whose priorities may legitimately change in response to changing political circumstances, macroeconomic governance derives much of its effectiveness from organizational continuity, technical credibility, and the preservation of organizational capabilities across successive governments.

The argument is therefore organizational rather than political. The claim is not that the MEF became insulated from democratic accountability or immune to ministerial replacement. Ministers continued to be appointed and dismissed by elected governments, and macroeconomic policy remained politically contestable. Rather, if the post-1990 organizational settlement selectively increased the strategic value of preserving macroeconomic governance, ministerial duration should be comparatively greater within the MEF than within organizations primarily responsible for political coordination. Under Axiom A3, such observable differences are interpreted as evidence consistent with comparatively stronger Protective Belts.

Three additional governmental organizations are incorporated for two complementary reasons. First, they broaden the organizational scope of the empirical analysis by allowing the principal comparison between the MEF and the PCM to be evaluated against organizations performing substantially different governmental functions. Second, they increase the amount of survival information available for empirical analysis, thereby permitting robustness analyses under alternative historical partitions and reducing the possibility that the principal findings reflect limited statistical power rather than theoretically meaningful organizational differences.

Beyond these methodological considerations, the Ministries of the Interior, Health, and Education also represent policy sectors that consistently rank among citizens' principal public concerns according to Peru's National Household Survey (ENAHU) and other official public opinion surveys conducted by the National Institute of Statistics (INEI, 2024). Incorporating these portfolios therefore extends the analysis beyond macroeconomic governance and political coordination to governmental organizations responsible for policy domains that citizens themselves identify as central priorities.

The Ministry of the Interior represents the state's coercive and internal security functions, whose organizational continuity has historically been shaped by terrorism, crime, police reform, and public order. The Ministries of Health and Education represent two of the state's largest providers of public services and address policy domains requiring sustained administrative capacity and long-term organizational development. Although these organizations also depend upon accumulated organizational knowledge, they were not strengthened by the post-1990 organizational settlement to the same extent as the institutions responsible for macroeconomic governance.

Together, these five governmental organizations represent contrasting organizational functions rather than merely different policy sectors. The PCM represents political coordination under conditions of continual political exposure. The MEF represents specialized macroeconomic governance under conditions requiring organizational continuity and technical credibility. Interior, Health, and Education provide organizational reference points operating under different administrative and political incentives. This configuration allows the empirical analyses to evaluate whether ministerial duration varies systematically across governmental organizations within the same Political Framework, as predicted by Proposition P2.

The empirical analyses do not seek to demonstrate that one governmental organization is inherently superior to another, nor that longer ministerial tenure necessarily produces more effective public policy. Rather, they examine whether Peru's historical trajectory exhibits observable patterns of ministerial duration consistent with the propositions derived from the deductive framework. Because organizational continuity, organizational knowledge accumulation, institutional learning, and Protective Belts remain latent theoretical constructs, the empirical analyses rely on observed ministerial duration as the empirical indicator through which the organizational implications of the theory are evaluated. The following section translates these theoretical expectations into an empirical research design.

4 Research Design

The theoretical framework developed in the previous sections distinguishes between latent organizational constructs and their observable empirical implications. Organizational continuity, organizational knowledge accumulation, institutional learning, and Protective Belts are not directly observable. Instead, the empirical analyses evaluate the two observable propositions derived from the axiomatic framework using ministerial duration as an empirical indicator.

The first proposition concerns historical variation across Political Frameworks. If successive Political Frameworks generate increasingly favorable organizational conditions for organizational knowledge accumulation, progressively longer patterns of ministerial duration should be observed across historical periods. The second proposition concerns organizational variation within Political Frameworks. If governmental organizations differ in the organizational protection surrounding their continuity, systematic differences in ministerial duration should be observed across ministerial portfolios operating under the same historical environment.

Ministerial duration constitutes the natural empirical indicator for evaluating both propositions because the observed outcome is the length of time ministers remain in office before replacement. Such data are characterized by time-to-event observations, right-censoring, and unequal exposure periods. These characteristics make survival analysis the appropriate statistical framework. Rather than estimating average ministerial tenure, survival models evaluate the probability that a minister remains in office over time while appropriately accounting for censored observations

and differing observation periods.

Accordingly, the empirical strategy proceeds in two stages. The first evaluates Proposition P1 by comparing survival patterns across successive Political Frameworks. The second evaluates Proposition P2 by comparing survival patterns across governmental organizations operating within the same Political Framework. Throughout both analyses, ministerial duration constitutes the observable outcome, while the latent theoretical constructs remain objects of interpretation rather than direct statistical estimation.

4.1 Data

The empirical analyses use an original longitudinal dataset recording every ministerial appointment in Peru from the beginning of the republican period through the present. Each observation corresponds to a single uninterrupted ministerial spell, beginning with the official appointment of a minister and ending upon replacement, resignation, dismissal, death, or the conclusion of the observation period.

For every ministerial spell, the dataset records the governmental organization (ministerial portfolio), the presidential administration responsible for the appointment, the corresponding Political Framework, and the duration of service measured in calendar days. Political Frameworks are assigned according to the historical operationalization developed in the previous section, whereas ministerial portfolios constitute the organizational units through which the theoretical framework is empirically examined.

Table ?? summarizes the structure of the ministerial spell dataset used in the empirical analyses.

Because some ministers remain in office at the conclusion of the observation period, the data contain right-censored observations. Survival analysis explicitly accommodates this feature by distinguishing completed ministerial spells from observations whose termination has not yet been observed.

4.2 Variables

Table 4 summarizes the observable variables employed throughout the empirical analyses, the role each plays in revealing the latent theoretical constructs, and the proposition to which each contributes. Rather than redefining the concepts introduced in the theoretical framework, the table clarifies how ministerial spell data are transformed into the indexed comparisons required by the empirical analyses.

4.3 Empirical Strategy

The empirical strategy follows directly from the deductive structure developed in Section 2. Each proposition generates a distinct observable implication and therefore requires a distinct empirical comparison. Proposition P1 concerns historical variation across Political Frameworks, whereas Proposition P2 concerns organizational

Table 3*Dataset Overview*

Item	Value
Unit of observation	Ministerial spell
Temporal coverage	1821–2026
Ministerial spells	1,069
Unique ministers	791
Presidents	124
Governmental organizations	MEF, Education, Interior, PCM, Health
Political Frameworks	6 Political Frameworks
Duration measure	Calendar days in office
Median duration	188.5 days
Mean duration	280.5 days
Duration range	1–2,059 days
Event definition	Exit from ministerial office
Right-censored observations	5

Note: The dataset contains one observation per ministerial spell. Duration is measured in calendar days in office. One day was added uniformly to all durations to avoid zero-length survival intervals. The event indicator equals one when a minister exited office and zero for right-censored observations.

variation across governmental portfolios operating within the same Political Framework. Although both propositions are evaluated using ministerial duration, they differ in the dimension along which duration is compared.

Historical comparison (P1). Proposition P1 is evaluated by comparing ministerial duration across successive Political Frameworks. The analysis therefore indexes duration by Political Framework (D_f) and examines whether later Political Frameworks exhibit progressively longer patterns of ministerial duration than their predecessors. Kaplan–Meier estimates provide the initial visual assessment of this historical ordering, whereas pairwise Cox comparisons evaluate whether the observed differences are consistent with the progression implied by the proposition.

Organizational comparison (P2). Proposition P2 is evaluated by comparing ministerial duration across governmental organizations operating within the same Political Framework. The analysis therefore indexes duration jointly by Political Framework and portfolio (D_{fp}), allowing organizational comparisons while holding the broader historical environment constant. Kaplan–Meier estimates describe the observed organizational differences, whereas pairwise Cox comparisons quantify the relative hazards associated with each organizational contrast.

4.4 Survival Analysis

Survival analysis provides the statistical framework for evaluating both propositions because ministerial duration constitutes time-to-event data characterized by unequal observation periods and a small number of right-censored observations.

Table 4

Operationalization of the Empirical Analysis

Observable	vari- able	Operation to reveal latent constructs	Used to evaluate
Political work	Frame- (PF_f)	Indexes the historical environments within which ministerial duration is evaluated. Comparing D_f across successive Political Frameworks reveals whether observed organizational continuity exhibits progressively longer patterns. Under Axioms A1 and A2, such patterns are interpreted as evidence regarding increasingly favorable conditions for organizational knowledge accumulation (K) and institutional learning (IL).	P1
Portfolio	(p)	Indexes governmental organizations operating within each Political Framework. Comparing D_{fp} across portfolios within the same Political Framework reveals whether organizational continuity differs systematically across governmental organizations. Under Axiom A3, these differences are interpreted as evidence consistent with differential Protective Belts (PB).	P2
Presidential administration	admin- (a)	Indexes executive contexts within which ministerial appointments and replacements occur. Conditioning on D_{fpa} accounts for executive-level heterogeneity affecting ministerial duration independently of the theoretical mechanisms.	Control
Ministerial duration	dura- (D)	Observed time in office. Depending on the analytical comparison, duration is summarized as D_f , D_{fp} , or D_{fpa} , providing the observable outcome through which the latent theoretical constructs are evaluated.	P1, P2

Note: Organizational continuity (C), organizational knowledge accumulation (K), institutional learning (IL), and Protective Belts (PB) are latent theoretical constructs and are therefore not directly observed. Ministerial duration provides the observable indicator through which these constructs are evaluated under the deductive framework developed in Section 3.

The empirical analyses proceed in two complementary stages. First, Kaplan–Meier estimators provide non-parametric descriptions of ministerial survival, allowing the observable implications of each proposition to be assessed directly from the empirical survival trajectories. Second, pairwise Cox proportional hazards models quantify the magnitude of the differences between the survival experiences of the relevant historical and organizational categories. Unlike a single reference-category specification, the pairwise comparisons evaluate every combination of Political Frameworks or governmental organizations, permitting the empirical analyses to identify where the historical or organizational trajectories depart from the theoretical expectations.

Model assumptions are evaluated using Schoenfeld residuals together with complementary graphical diagnostics.

5 Results

5.1 Proposition 1: Ministerial Duration across Political Frameworks

Proposition P1 predicts that successive Political Frameworks should exhibit progressively longer patterns of ministerial duration. Its observable implication is therefore that ministers serving under later Political Frameworks should exhibit higher survival probabilities over time than ministers serving under earlier Political Frameworks. Under Axioms A1 and A2, progressively longer ministerial duration is interpreted as evidence of increasingly favorable organizational conditions for organizational knowledge accumulation and institutional learning.

Figure ?? presents the Kaplan–Meier survival estimates for the six Political Frameworks.

5.1.1 *Kaplan–Meier Estimates*

The Kaplan–Meier estimates provide an initial visual assessment of Proposition P1. The proposition is intentionally formulated as a strong inequality. Rather than asking whether ministerial duration generally tends to increase over time, it requires each successive Political Framework to exhibit longer duration than its predecessor. This demanding formulation transforms the proposition into a diagnostic device, allowing the empirical analysis not only to assess the overall historical trajectory but also to identify the specific Political Frameworks at which that trajectory departs from monotonicity.

If successive Political Frameworks generated progressively more favorable organizational conditions for continuity, the median survival times should follow the historical ordering of the Political Frameworks. The numbered labels identify each Political Framework at the point where its estimated survival function reaches the median survival probability ($S = 0.5$). Under complete support for Proposition P1, the expected ordering would therefore be

$$PF_1 < PF_2 < PF_3 < PF_4 < PF_5 < PF_6,$$

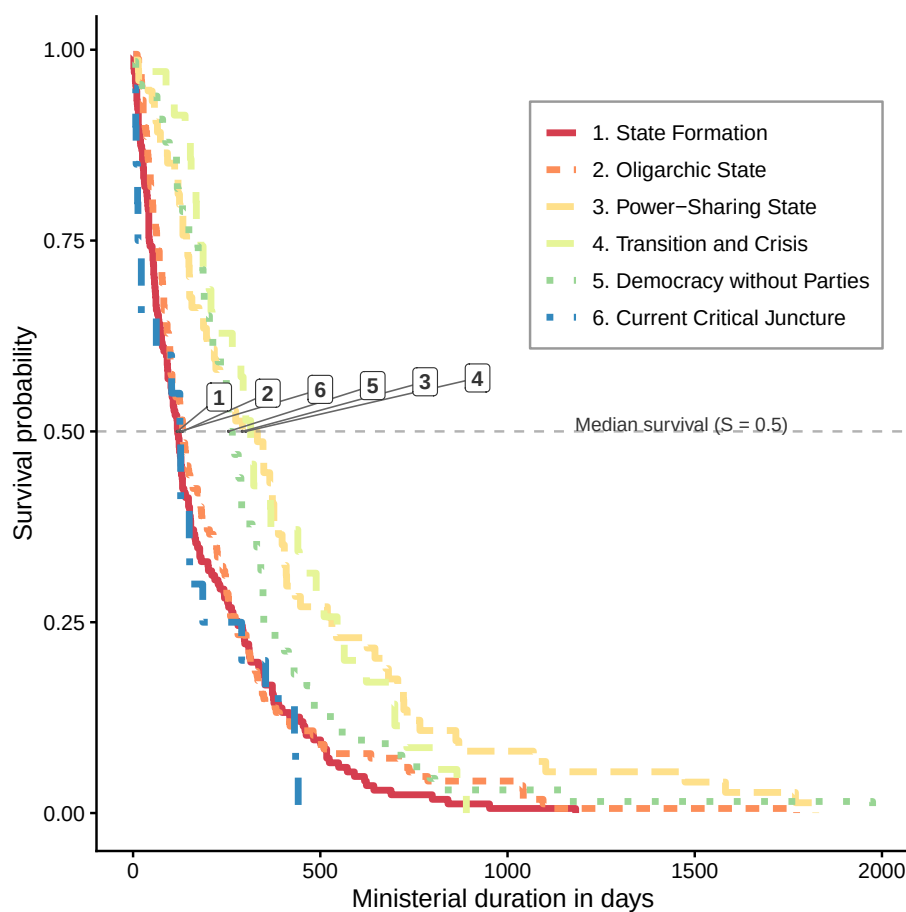


Figure 2

KaplanMeier estimates of ministerial continuity across political frameworks. Curves represent the estimated probability that a minister remains in office beyond a given duration. Numbers identify the six political frameworks listed in Table 2. Analyses are restricted to appointments to the Presidency of the Council of Ministers (PCM) and the Ministry of Economy and Finance (MEF).

where each successive Political Framework exhibits longer ministerial duration than its predecessor.

The observed ordering is only partially consistent with this expectation. Among the first four completed Political Frameworks, the median survival times increase monotonically, producing the ordering

$$PF_1 < PF_2 < PF_3 < PF_4.$$

This pattern is fully consistent with the proposition. The historical trajectory changes, however, with the fifth Political Framework, whose median ministerial duration falls below those observed under both the third and fourth Political Frameworks. The sixth Political Framework exhibits an even shorter median duration, although this result should be interpreted cautiously because it corresponds to an ongoing Critical Juncture rather than a completed Political Framework.

The strict formulation of Proposition P1 is intentionally demanding. A weaker interpretation would require only that later Political Frameworks tend to exhibit longer ministerial duration than earlier ones, allowing occasional departures from strict monotonicity. Even under this more permissive interpretation, however, the fifth Political Framework remains historically distinctive because it reverses the trajectory established by the preceding completed Political Frameworks.

This departure from monotonicity should not be interpreted as contradicting the comparative-historical reconstruction developed by Lopez Jimenez et al. (2025). That reconstruction identifies successive Political Frameworks as the enduring political legacies of completed Critical Junctures and argues that these legacies progressively broaden political incorporation and democratization. It does not propose that organizational continuity or institutional learning should improve monotonically over time. Proposition P1 introduces a different theoretical question: whether these successive political legacies also generated progressively more favorable organizational conditions for institutional learning.

From this perspective, Figure 2 suggests that political development and organizational learning need not follow identical historical trajectories. Organizational continuity appears to improve systematically across the first four completed Political Frameworks, but the post-1993 political settlement does not extend that earlier trajectory. Rather than representing a contradiction of the Critical Junctures framework, the fifth Political Framework identifies the point at which Peru’s political evolution and the organizational conditions for institutional learning appear to diverge. The pairwise Cox analyses reported below quantify these historical differences and identify the Political Frameworks between which they become statistically distinguishable.

5.1.2 *Cox Proportional Hazards Model*

The Kaplan–Meier estimates describe the observed historical trajectory of ministerial survival, but they do not estimate the magnitude of differences between Political Frameworks. To identify where the historical trajectory departs from the mono-

tonic expectation implied by Proposition P1, Table 5 reports pairwise Cox proportional hazards comparisons across Political Frameworks. Each cell compares the replacement hazard of the column Political Framework against the row Political Framework. Because the matrix involves multiple pairwise comparisons, reported p -values are adjusted using the Holm procedure for multiple comparisons.

Table 5

Pairwise Cox Comparisons across Political Frameworks

Reference	2. Oligarchic State	3. Power-Sharing State	4. Transition and Crisis	5. Democracy without Parties	6. Current Critical Juncture
1. State Formation	0.88 (1.00000)	0.47 (< 0.001)	0.50 (0.00247)	0.61 (0.00863)	1.24 (1.00000)
2. Oligarchic State	NA	0.55 (< 0.001)	0.58 (0.03342)	0.65 (0.03342)	1.31 (1.00000)
3. Power-Sharing State	NA	NA	1.07 (1.00000)	1.27 (1.00000)	2.60 (0.00344)
4. Transition and Crisis	NA	NA	NA	1.30 (1.00000)	3.35 (0.00138)
5. Democracy without Parties	NA	NA	NA	NA	2.07 (0.03987)

Note: Cells report hazard ratios from pairwise Cox proportional hazards models, with Holm-adjusted p -values in parentheses. Each row category is the reference group; each column category is the comparison group. Hazard ratios below one indicate lower ministerial replacement hazard in the column Political Framework relative to the row Political Framework. Analyses are restricted to PCM and MEF appointments.

The pairwise Cox comparisons confirm that the principal historical discontinuity separates the first two Political Frameworks from the subsequent completed Political Frameworks. Relative to PF1 and PF2, the hazards of ministerial replacement decline substantially under PF3, PF4, and PF5. However, the pairwise comparisons among PF3, PF4, and PF5 are not statistically distinguishable. Rather than supporting a continuous stepwise increase in ministerial continuity, the evidence suggests the emergence of a new historical regime characterized by substantially greater organizational continuity than that observed during the first two Political Frameworks.

The sixth Political Framework departs sharply from this pattern. Its replacement hazard is significantly higher than those observed under PF3, PF4, and PF5, reinforcing the interpretation that the current Critical Juncture represents an unsettled historical environment rather than a completed Political Framework comparable to the previous periods.

Taken together, the Kaplan–Meier estimates and the pairwise Cox comparisons provide qualified support for Proposition P1. The evidence is inconsistent with the proposition’s strongest formulation requiring a monotonic increase across every successive Political Framework. Nevertheless, it supports the broader theoretical expectation that Peru’s organizational conditions for institutional continuity improved substantially relative to the earliest historical environments. The principal exception is the post-1993 Political Framework, which interrupts the earlier trajectory of increasing continuity despite representing a durable political legacy within the comparative-historical reconstruction. This finding suggests that the historical evolution of Peru’s political institutions and the organizational conditions for institutional learning followed partially independent trajectories.

5.2 Proposition 2: Ministerial Duration across Governmental Organizations

Proposition P2 predicts that governmental organizations operating within the same Political Framework should exhibit systematically different patterns of ministerial duration according to the organizational protection surrounding their accumulated knowledge. Its observable implication is therefore that ministerial survival should differ across governmental organizations while holding the historical environment constant. Under Axiom A3, comparatively longer ministerial duration is interpreted as evidence consistent with stronger Protective Belts preserving organizational continuity.

The principal comparison concerns the Ministry of Economy and Finance (MEF) and the Presidency of the Council of Ministers (PCM). As discussed in the previous section, these organizations occupy comparable positions within the executive branch but perform fundamentally different organizational functions. The MEF concentrates specialized macroeconomic capabilities whose effectiveness depends heavily upon accumulated organizational knowledge, whereas the PCM serves primarily as the executive's principal organization for political coordination. If Protective Belts emerge selectively around organizational knowledge that is particularly valuable to the prevailing Political Framework, the MEF should exhibit greater ministerial continuity than the PCM within each historical environment.

Figure ?? therefore presents Kaplan–Meier estimates comparing ministerial survival in the MEF and the PCM separately for each Political Framework.

5.2.1 *Kaplan–Meier Estimates*

The Kaplan–Meier estimates provide an initial visual assessment of Proposition P2. Unlike Proposition P1, the second proposition does not predict a historical ordering among Political Frameworks. Instead, it evaluates whether governmental organizations exhibit systematically different patterns of ministerial continuity while operating within the same historical environment.

The principal empirical comparison therefore concerns the Ministry of Economy and Finance (MEF) and the Presidency of the Council of Ministers (PCM). As discussed in the previous section, both organizations occupy central positions within the executive branch and are indispensable to the operation of government. The comparison is therefore not between organizations of unequal political importance, but between organizations performing fundamentally different organizational functions. Whereas the PCM is responsible for political coordination and coalition management, the MEF concentrates the specialized technical capabilities required for macroeconomic governance.

Under Proposition P2, organizational differences should emerge while holding the Political Framework constant. Figure 3 therefore presents separate Kaplan–Meier estimates for each Political Framework, allowing ministerial continuity to be com-

pared between the MEF and the PCM under the same historical conditions. If Protective Belts selectively preserve organizational continuity, the MEF should exhibit consistently higher survival probabilities than the PCM across completed Political Frameworks.

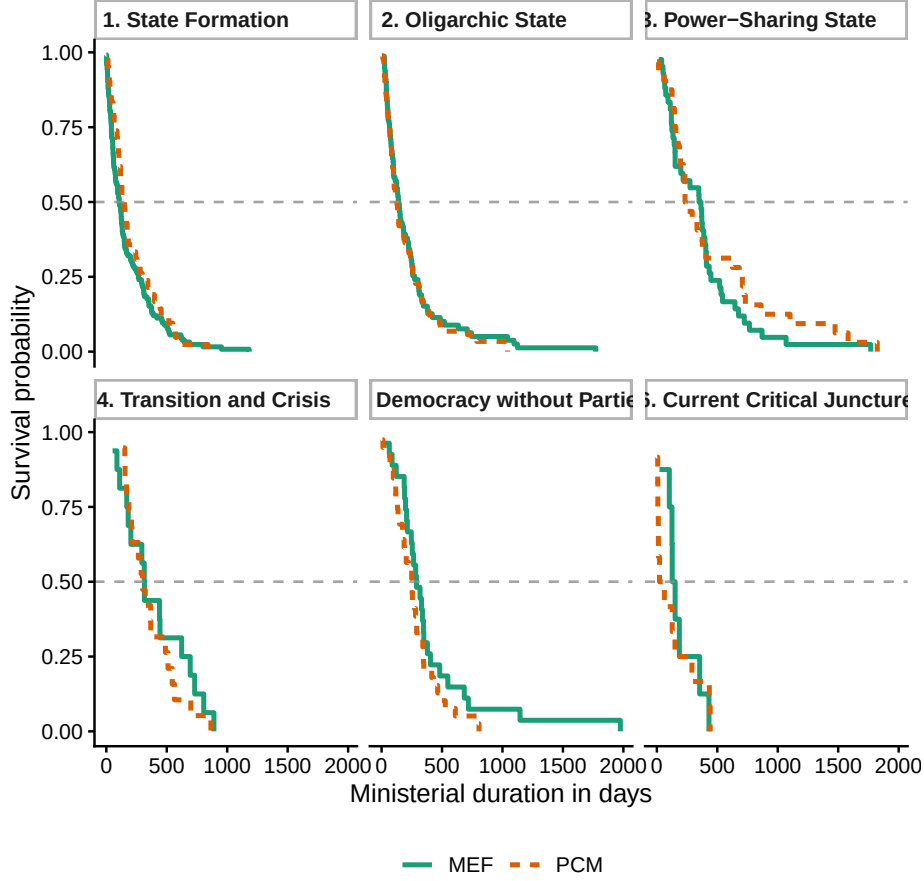


Figure 3

Kaplan–Meier estimates of ministerial continuity for the MEF and PCM within Political Frameworks. Curves represent the estimated probability that a minister remains in office beyond a given duration. Facets hold the Political Framework constant while comparing ministerial portfolios.

The Kaplan–Meier estimates provide an initial visual assessment of Proposition P2. Unlike Proposition P1, the second proposition does not predict a historical ordering among Political Frameworks. Instead, it evaluates whether organizational differences in ministerial continuity emerge while the historical environment remains constant. Each panel therefore compares the two organizations within the same Political Framework.

The comparison is theoretically demanding because both the MEF and the

PCM occupy central positions within the executive branch. Neither organization can be considered politically peripheral. The PCM serves as the executive's principal organization for political coordination, whereas the MEF performs the central functions of macroeconomic governance. Proposition P2 therefore does not compare organizations of different institutional importance, but organizations of comparable executive centrality performing fundamentally different organizational functions.

The first two Political Frameworks reveal little systematic difference between the two organizations. Beginning with the third Political Framework, however, the survival trajectories begin to separate. The divergence becomes particularly pronounced under the fourth and fifth Political Frameworks, where ministers in the MEF consistently exhibit higher survival probabilities than their counterparts in the PCM. This pattern is consistent with the expectation that the organizational capabilities embedded within macroeconomic governance became progressively more costly to disrupt as Peru's post-reform institutional settlement consolidated. By contrast, the sixth Political Framework again exhibits little separation between the two organizations, consistent with the broader organizational instability associated with the ongoing Critical Juncture.

5.2.2 *Cox Proportional Hazards Model with Presidential Frailty*

The Kaplan–Meier estimates compare the observed survival trajectories of the MEF and the PCM within each Political Framework, but they do not account for unobserved heterogeneity across presidential administrations. This is especially important for Proposition P2, since some presidents may be systematically more prone to cabinet turnover than others. To account for this executive-level dependence, the Cox models include a shared frailty term for presidential administration.

For each Political Framework, the model estimates whether MEF ministers face a different hazard of replacement than PCM ministers while allowing ministerial spells under the same president to share unobserved administration-specific risk. Hazard ratios below one indicate that MEF ministers face a lower replacement hazard than PCM ministers within the same Political Framework.

The frailty-adjusted Cox model provides more qualified evidence than the Kaplan–Meier estimates. Across most Political Frameworks, the MEF–PCM difference is not statistically distinguishable once unobserved presidential-level heterogeneity is taken into account. The exception is PF5, where MEF ministers face a substantially lower replacement hazard than PCM ministers ($HR = 0.63$, $p = 0.073$). Although this contrast falls short of conventional levels of statistical significance, its magnitude and direction are consistent with the expectation that the post-1993 settlement generated stronger organizational protection around macroeconomic governance.

These results suggest that Proposition P2 receives limited but theoretically meaningful support. Protective Belts do not appear as a general property of the MEF across the entire republican period. Rather, the evidence indicates that the

Table 6*MEF–PCM Hazard Ratios within Political Frameworks*

Political Framework	Hazard ratio	95% CI	p-value
1. State Formation	1.27	[0.80, 2.01]	0.3166
2. Oligarchic State	0.83	[0.55, 1.26]	0.3832
3. Power-Sharing State	1.31	[0.72, 2.38]	0.3793
4. Transition and Crisis	0.85	[0.41, 1.75]	0.6532
5. Democracy without Parties	0.63	[0.38, 1.04]	0.0731
6. Current Critical Juncture	0.75	[0.30, 1.83]	0.5213

Note: Hazard ratios compare MEF ministers to PCM ministers within each Political Framework. Values below one indicate a lower hazard of ministerial replacement for MEF ministers relative to PCM ministers. Estimates are derived from a single Cox proportional hazards model including portfolio, Political Framework, their interaction, and a shared frailty term for presidential administration. Reported p-values correspond to pre-specified within-framework MEF–PCM contrasts.

MEF advantage emerges most clearly under the fifth Political Framework, precisely the period in which macroeconomic governance became central to the operation of the post-1990 political settlement.

6 Robustness Analysis: The Organizational Consolidation of Globalization

6.1 Robustness to the Organizational Consolidation of Globalization

The previous analyses operationalized historical environments using the Political Frameworks derived from completed Critical Junctures. As discussed in Section ..., however, the organizational consolidation of Peru’s post-1990 macroeconomic institutions occurred gradually throughout the subsequent decade rather than immediately following the 1993 constitutional settlement. Consequently, the fifth Political Framework potentially combines two distinct organizational environments: an initial period during which the organizational reconstruction remained incomplete and a later period in which the post-reform institutional architecture had largely consolidated.

The analyses reported below therefore examine whether the principal findings remain robust after partitioning the fifth Political Framework according to the consolidation of the globalization reforms.

The globalization cut clarifies the historical pattern suggested by the Political Framework analysis. Before 2001, MEF and PCM ministers exhibit virtually identical replacement hazards ($HR = 1.04$). After 2001, the MEF hazard falls below the PCM hazard ($HR = 0.70$), indicating a roughly 30 percent lower risk of ministerial replacement. Although this contrast is not statistically significant at conventional levels, its direction and magnitude are consistent with the interpretation that the organizational advantage of the MEF emerges only after the consolidation of the

Table 7*MEF–PCM Hazard Ratios before and after Globalization Consolidation*

Period	Hazard ratio	95% CI	p-value
1821–2000	1.04	[0.80, 1.35]	0.763
2001–Present	0.70	[0.44, 1.13]	0.145

Note: Hazard ratios compare MEF ministers to PCM ministers within each period. Values below one indicate a lower hazard of ministerial replacement for MEF ministers relative to PCM ministers. The cut at 2001 distinguishes the historical period before and after the consolidation of the post-1990 globalization reforms. Estimates are derived from a single Cox proportional hazards model including portfolio, period, their interaction, and a shared frailty term for presidential administration. Reported p-values correspond to pre-specified MEF–PCM contrasts within each period.

post-1990 globalization reforms.

Table 8*Ministerial Replacement Relative to the MEF before and after Globalization Consolidation*

Period	Portfolio	Hazard ratio	95% CI	p-value
1821–2000	PCM	0.96	[0.75, 1.23]	0.72983
1821–2000	Interior	0.90	[0.73, 1.11]	0.33163
1821–2000	Education	0.78	[0.63, 0.97]	0.02640
1821–2000	Health	0.69	[0.49, 0.98]	0.03626
2001–Present	PCM	1.42	[0.88, 2.29]	0.14794
2001–Present	Interior	1.83	[1.16, 2.90]	0.00987
2001–Present	Education	0.87	[0.51, 1.48]	0.61588
2001–Present	Health	0.94	[0.56, 1.58]	0.81372

Note: Hazard ratios compare each portfolio to the Ministry of Economy and Finance (MEF) within each period. Values above one indicate a greater hazard of ministerial replacement than the MEF. Estimates are derived from a single Cox proportional hazards model including portfolio, globalization period, their interaction, and a shared frailty term for presidential administration. Reported p-values correspond to pre-specified within-period portfolio contrasts relative to the MEF.

Table 8 extends the MEF comparison to the broader set of governmental organizations. Before 2001, the MEF does not exhibit a general continuity advantage. The PCM and Interior portfolios are statistically indistinguishable from the MEF, while Education and Health exhibit significantly lower replacement hazards. After 2001, however, the pattern changes. The PCM and Interior portfolios display higher replacement hazards than the MEF, with the Interior contrast reaching conventional

levels of statistical significance. Education and Health remain statistically indistinguishable from the MEF.

These results reinforce the interpretation that the MEF advantage is historically contingent rather than inherent to the portfolio. The evidence does not suggest that the MEF was consistently protected throughout the republican period. Instead, its relative continuity becomes more apparent after the consolidation of the post-1990 globalization reforms, particularly when compared to organizations more directly exposed to political coordination, internal security, and recurrent crisis management.

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